

Landlord Outreach Scripts

THE #1 RULE: SPEED

Good Philly rentals get 20+ inquiries in 48 hours. Most say only “is this available?” — which landlords ignore. Your message answers their screening questions before they ask. Check listings twice a day (8am and 5pm — most new listings post mornings) and reply within minutes, not hours.

Script 1: First Contact (text or email)

“Hi, I’m [name] — very interested in [address]. Quick intro: I’m a [job] at [employer], [X] years there, gross income \$[X]/month. Looking to move [date] with [household — e.g., my partner and one cat]. My documents, references, and deposit are ready now. Could I see the unit [two specific options: ‘Thursday after 5 or Saturday morning’]? I’ve attached a one-page renter profile.”

Why it works: income, timing, household, readiness — the four screening questions — answered in 5 sentences, plus a specific viewing ask they can say yes to.

Script 2: No Reply After 48 Hours

“Hi [name], following up on [address] — still very interested and can tour any evening this week. If it’s already spoken for, no problem, but I’d appreciate knowing either way. Thanks!”

One follow-up only. Two looks eager; three looks desperate.

Script 3: Same Day After the Tour

“Thank you for showing me [address] today — I’d love to move forward. My application and documents are attached / submitted. My references are expecting your call. Is there anything else you need from me to make a decision?”

Script 4: Getting Ahead of a Credit Issue

Use AFTER they show interest but BEFORE you pay an application fee:

“One thing I want to be upfront about: my credit score is around [X] due to [one phrase — old medical collections]. My last [X] months of rent are paid on time and verifiable, and I can offer [autopay / a cosigner / extra deposit]. If that’s workable within your criteria, I’d love to apply — I just don’t want to waste your time or my application fee.”

This filters out automatic denials for free, and the honesty itself wins over private landlords regularly.

Script 5: Housing Voucher Holder

"Hi, I'm [name], very interested in [address]. I have a Housing Choice Voucher that covers \$ [X] of the rent; my portion is \$[X], backed by [income source]. The voucher means the bulk of the rent arrives reliably every month directly from PHA. I'm ready to start the paperwork immediately and my documents are organized to make the process fast. Could I set up a tour this week?"

Note: refusing to rent to you BECAUSE of a voucher (source-of-income discrimination) is illegal in Philadelphia. If it happens, save the messages and report it to the Philadelphia Commission on Human Relations (phila.gov/phr, 215-686-4670). For the complete voucher game plan — timeline, RFTA, inspection, and how to keep landlords engaged through the process — see the [Philly Voucher Navigation Guide](#).

Script 6: The "Keep Me in Mind"

When a unit is taken, don't waste the contact — landlords usually own more than one property:

"Totally understand — congrats on filling it. If you have other units now or coming up in [neighborhoods], I'd love to be your first call: [one-line summary — income, household, move date]. I'll keep my profile current."

What NOT to Say — Ever

- "Is this still available?" with nothing else — the most-ignored message in real estate
- Your life story, hardships, or urgency ("I need to be out by Friday") in a first message
- "Is the landlord flexible on rent/deposit/credit?" before they've met you
- Anything negotiable before the tour — get in the door first